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### Performance Final Draft

Claim: Marvel's rapid-fire content model has traded its once-bold storytelling for a safe, assembly-line formula, diluting creativity and leaving audiences craving genuine originality.

Slide 1: Who has seen a Marvel movie? Who has seen the latest Marvel movie Thunderbolts\*?  
(Hopefully not as many raise their hand) Exactly!

Slide 2: Today I will be discussing why Marvel has fallen from its once great empire into a boring formulaic content making machine.

Slide 3: First let's discuss Marvel's Golden Age and see what went wrong.

Slide 4: In the early 2010s, Marvel movies weren't just movies, they were big events. (click)  
When Iron Man was first shown in 2008, it was a huge success. A lesser known Marvel hero got its own movie and it was praised for being witty and grounded, audiences fell in love with Tony Stark. (Click) Captain America: The First Avenger released in 2011 followed with a super soldier patriotic hero in a world war 2 setting (Click) and Thor immersed us into Nordic lore. What do all these films have in common? They all felt unique, one was a gritty war drama with little cgi and the other was a fish out of water fantasy. This all culminates with ...

Slide 5: The Avengers! A rarely seen crossover spectacle with characters that we all learned to love over the past couple of years. This movie was a hit loved by fans and critics.

Slide 6: Marvel did not slow down there; they proved fearless from the (click) cosmic oddballs of Guardians of the Galaxy to the street-level heist film (click) Ant-Man, each new hero caused conversation and inspired fan discussion. I remember personally seeing the trailer for Guardians of the Galaxy and thinking Marvel had lost their sh\*t after The Avengers and now it's one of my favorite trilogies.

Slide 7: This all changed in 2019 with the release of Avenger's Endgame which culminated the story of many beloved characters and was loved by many. This very well could have been where Marvel ended their franchise and rebooted it all.

Slide 8: So is that how it ends? Does Marvel end the franchise there and we live happily ever after.

Slide 9: NO!

Slide 10: We don't get happy ever after because right after endgame we get hit with COVID where we all get locked into our homes for a whole year. (Click)The COVID-19 pandemic shut down theaters and catapulted us into the streaming era.

Slide 11: This leads me to Phase 4 where the real downfall begins.

Slide 12: Marvel responds to COVID by flooding Disney+ with series and ramping up movie production: Phase 4 delivers 12 new titles in just four years, compared to the 1-2 a year pace of its golden age. It might seem that this would be great for fans but something important was slipping away.

Slide 13: Movies were all just sequels and using characters we had already been introduced to. They were all unoriginal and following a boring template pg-13 jokes every minute, a doomsday threat that only a couple heroes respond to for some reason and a huge cgi fight.

Slide 14: The franchise's average Rotten Tomatoes score plunged from 85 percent (2012–19) to 65 percent (2020–24). Audiences, once first in line at midnight premieres, now just wait for the Disney+ drop. Sequels feel safe rather than surprising, sparking “franchise fatigue” that undermines narrative engagement, as media scholar J. Smith argues in the *Journal of Media Studies*.

Slide 15: Why should we care? Because original stories push culture forward (Kimmerer, 2020). Fresh narratives expand empathy, spotlight underrepresented voices. They challenge us to see the world differently.

Slide 16: We saw this with Shang Chi and the legend of the 10 rings that scored 92 percent on Rotten Tomatoes showing that audiences still crave inventive storytelling. If we let studios continue making these copy and paste films we risk losing bold voices as diverse filmmakers will be sidelined for what studios believe would guarantee box office success. I don't want to leave on a bad note. We can fix this.

Slide 17: We have power, by voting with our wallets and choosing original titles, we send a clear signal that creativity matters more than familiarity.

Slide 19: So next time you scroll through streaming menus or scan the theater listings, choose the innovative and new.

Slide 20: Thank you for your time.

## Work Cited

Kimmerer, R. (2020). *Braiding Sweetgrass*. Scholarly discussion of storytelling's role in cultural growth.

Smith, J. (2023). "Franchise Fatigue: The Psychology of Over-Exposure," *Journal of Media Studies*, 15(2), 45–62.

Box Office Mojo, "Marvel Cinematic Universe Franchise Summary," accessed May 2025.

Rotten Tomatoes, "Tomatometer for Marvel Films," accessed May 2025.